



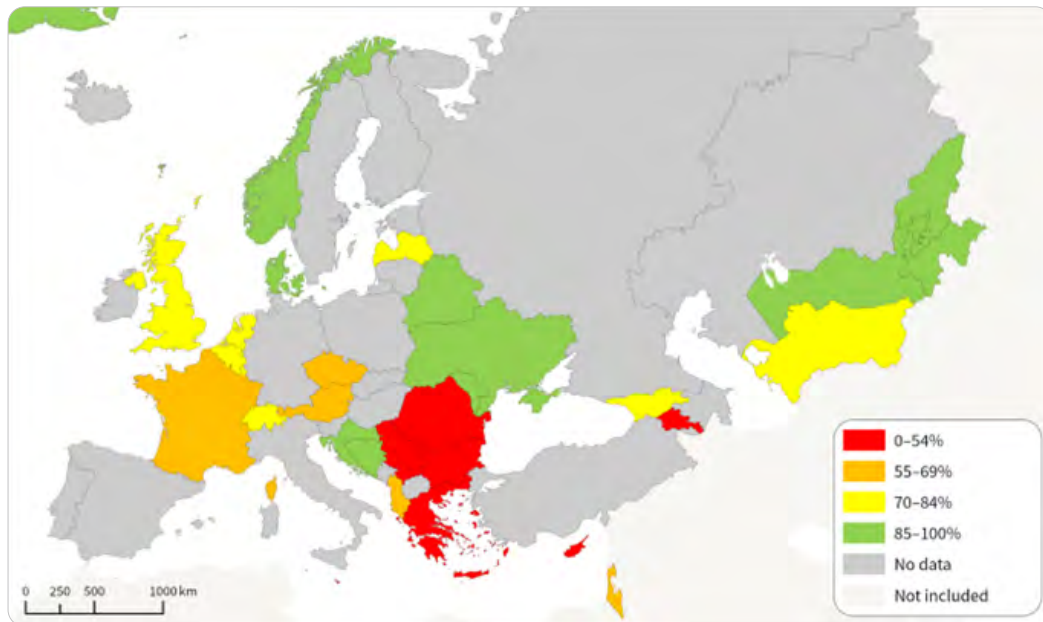
# EUROPE HAS THE LOWEST BREASTFEEDING RATES IN THE WORLD

## CHILD AND ADOLESCENT HEALTH IN THE WHO EUROPEAN REGION: BREASTFEEDING FACT SHEET



Too many newborns are not breastfed within their first hour of life

### THE PREVALENCE OF BREASTFEEDING INITIATION WITHIN THE FIRST HOUR OF LIFE



Source: © WHO

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- Hospitals do not ensure **initiation of breastfeeding** in the first hour of life.
- Too many babies receive **breastmilk substitutes** within the first two days of life.
- The **Baby Friendly Hospital Initiative** is not widely implemented within and across countries.
- **Exclusive breastfeeding** rates at six months of life vary widely in the Region.

#### WHY IS THIS IMPORTANT?

- Delaying the initiation of breastfeeding after birth can have life-threatening consequences.
- Breastfeeding **reduces the risk** of diarrhoea, pneumonia and asthma.
- Breastfeeding has **protective effects against** obesity and noncommunicable diseases later in life.
- It contributes to the **health and well being** of mothers too, reducing the risks of ovarian and breast cancer.

#### SUCCESSFUL GOVERNANCE:

- Adopts and implement the standards set up by the Baby Friendly Hospital Initiative.
- Fully implements the International Code of Marketing of Breast Milk Substitutes and relevant World Health Assembly resolutions.
- Regulates and enforces restrictions on the marketing of infant formula.
- Enacts paid family leave and workplace regulations to facilitate breastfeeding practices.
- Invests in training and capacity building of doctors, midwives and nurses in the areas of breastfeeding protection, promotion and support.
- Collects data on breastfeeding rates and practices to track progress to achieve global breastfeeding targets.
- Ensures that primary health care providers encourage exclusive breastfeeding for six months.